war broke out in Europe in 1939, President Roosevelt issued an ‘urgent appeal to every Government which may be engaged in hostilities publicly to affirm its determination that its armed forces shall in no event, and under no circumstances, undertake the bombardment of civilians or of unfortified cities.’[17]

Early endeavours to refrain from bombing cities gave way to new strategies for air warfare. The British attack on Hamburg in 1943 (which created the first ever firestorm) killed an estimated 42,000 civilians.[18] Estimates vary of casualties in the bombing of Dresden in February 1945 (where another firestorm occurred), though 25,000-40,000 is a generally accepted range. By 1945 the USAAF was embarked on the systematic destruction of Japan’s cities. The firebombing of Tokyo on 9-10 March 1945 killed an estimated 100,000 people and involved 2,000 tons of incendiary bombs (equivalent to two kilotons). General Curtis LeMay, then commander of the Seventh Army Air Force, observed, ‘We scorched and boiled and baked to death more people in Tokyo on the night of 9-10 March than went up in vapor at Hiroshima and Nagasaki combined.’[19] LeMay was not a man given to euphemisms, and was also wont to speak his mind. When chief of staff of the USAF during the Cuban missile crisis he made clear his strong objections to President Kennedy’s preference for a naval blockade of Cuba over an invasion.

Deaths from bombing might in turn be put in other grim contexts, such as the German sieges of Sevastopol in 1942 and Leningrad between 1941 and 1944 (where some 800,000 to 1,000,000 civilians died). When the Japanese invaded China in 1937-8, Japanese soldiers killed between 40,000 and 300,000 people in Nanjing and raped some 20,000 women. In Europe, six to seven million people were murdered in Nazi concentration and extermination camps, six million of them Jewish. Two million Soviet prisoners of war perished in German captivity.

In the film *Dr Strangelove*, when General Turgidson addresses President Muffley, there is a file on his desk labelled ‘World Targets in Megadeaths.’ Comprehending the explosive yields of fission (atomic or A-bomb) and fusion (thermonuclear or hydrogen/H-bomb) weapons can be mind-numbing. It is difficult to grasp the enormity of the destruction. Invariably,